

April-May 1940
GERMANY LAUNCHES
BLITZKRIEG CAMPAIGNS
IN WESTERN EUROPE

After seven months of limited activity (later dubbed the “Phoney War”), Hitler ordered the invasion first of Denmark and Norway, which were both overcome within months, and then of Belgium and the Netherlands. From the Low Countries, German forces struck southward into France, capturing Paris by mid-June. An armistice was signed soon after, leaving much of the country in German hands.

▷ German troops in Paris



23 March 1940 The All-India Muslim League declares for a separate state of Pakistan

30 March 1940 Japanese invaders set up a puppet Chinese government in Nanjing

◁ British Supermarine Spitfire fighter aircraft

27 September 1940 Japan, Germany, and Italy form a military coalition; they are known as the “Axis powers”

1940



“Never in the field of human conflict was so much owed by so many to so few.”

WINSTON CHURCHILL, 1940

10 July 1940
THE BATTLE OF BRITAIN BEGINS
FOR CONTROL OF THE SKIES

British land forces confronting the German advance in the Low Countries had been made to retreat to Britain from Dunkirk. Now Hitler launched an air campaign to win control of British airspace as a preliminary to a land invasion. Called the “Battle of Britain” by the new Prime Minister, Winston Churchill, the campaign lasted almost a year, during which time London and other cities endured the massive bombing campaign known as the Blitz.